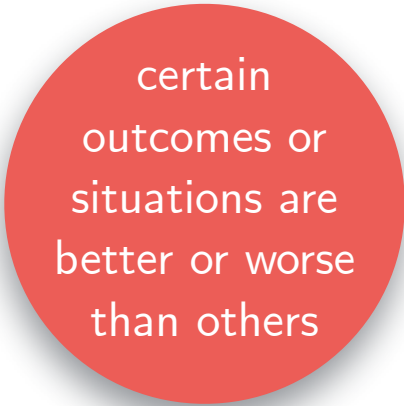




certain actions
are right or
wrong



certain
outcomes or
situations are
better or worse
than others

A solid green circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "certain people or lives are better or worse than others" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in five lines.

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people or lives
are better or
worse than
others

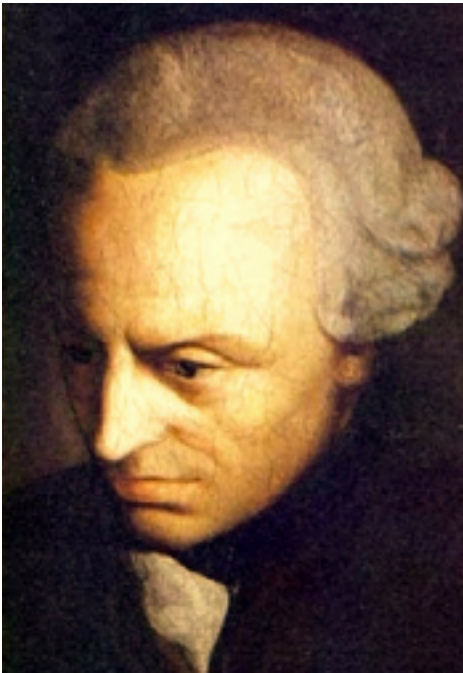
The consequentialist takes the goodness or badness of situations as fundamental, and tries to explain the others in terms of these. What would it look like if we took one of the other categories as most fundamental?

A **deontological** approach to what we ought to do takes facts about the rightness and wrongness of actions as basic, and does not try to explain the rightness or wrongness of actions in terms of the goodness or badness of the action's outcomes.

There are lots of different deontological theories. I'm going to briefly introduce you to one, which is based on the idea that people have certain basic **rights**. On this view, wrong actions are actions which violate someone's rights.

But what are rights, and which actions violate them?

One answer to this question was given by the 18th century German philosopher Immanuel Kant.



Kant thought that all human beings have dignity, and that this means that we all have the right not to be used as a way to satisfy the desires of others.

He called this view 'the law of humanity':

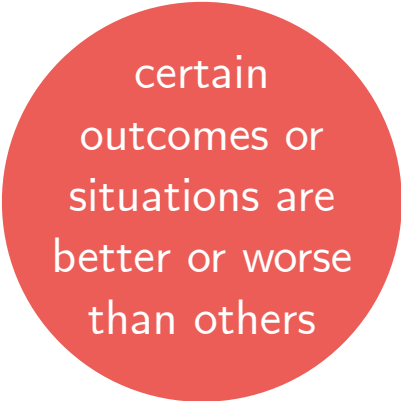
‘Act in such a way that you always treat humanity,
whether in your own person or the person of any
other, never simply as a means, but always at the same
time as an end.’

What does it mean to use someone as a means to an end, versus treating them as an end in themselves? Think of the complaint that someone is simply using you. When we say this, we are saying that the person is not taking you into account; that he is treating you as a vehicle for his own ends, rather than as deserving respect and consideration in your own right. This is treating someone as a mere means rather than as an end in himself.

That said, it is important to see that the formula of humanity does not prohibit using someone as a means to an end, but only doing so without also treating them as an end in themselves. When you order food at a restaurant you are treating the person to whom you place the order as a means - but this is only a violation of the formula of humanity if, in so doing, you don't also treat them as an end in themselves.



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